

Simone Poggesi

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About Me

My path into food science began with a curiosity for applied chemistry at technical high school and evolved through viticulture, oenology, and biosensor research in France. A career-defining pivot occurred during my Ph.D. when I took over our laboratory's sensory panels. That transition led me to Massey University's Feast Lab in New Zealand alongside Prof. Joanne Hort, where I led industry consumer research and served as Principal Investigator on competitive grants integrating virtual environments (VR), AI/NLP thematic analysis, and implicit consumer testing. Immersing myself in New Zealand reshaped both my personal relationship with food—cooking from scratch—and my leadership philosophy: bridging diverse cultures while guiding team members so everyone feels genuinely seen, valued, and empowered. Returning to industry as R&D Manager at Giotto Consulting in Italy provided a pragmatic reality check on research market value. Crossing countries, disciplines, and sectors has made me an adaptable researcher who bridges technical food engineering, qualitative consumer insights, and empathetic team leadership.

Education

Ph.D. in Food Engineering and Biotechnology 2019 – 2023

Free University of Bozen-Bolzano, Italy

Thesis: Advances in profiling and preserving the identity of wines: sensory and chemometric approaches.

Master Degree in Viticulture, Oenology and Wine Market 2016 – 2019

University of Udine, Italy

Thesis: Construction of platforms for ultrasensitive real-time detection of *Brettanomyces bruxellensis* in wines.

Bachelor Degree in Viticulture and Oenology 2012 – 2016

University of Udine, Italy

Academic & Professional Experience

R&D Manager Oct 2025 – Present

Giotto Consulting Srl Unipersonale, Italy

- Author technical R&D proposals, experimental designs, and data-driven strategies for corporate food and beverage clients across Europe.
- Translate technical analytical data and consumer requirements into actionable solutions for industrial stakeholders.
- Develop digital tools and data-management solutions to improve analytical workflows and operational efficiency.

Research Officer (Sensory & Consumer Science) Sep 2022 – Sep 2025

Food Experience and Sensory Testing Laboratory (Feast) - Massey University, New Zealand

- Led major research initiatives connecting industry clients across New Zealand with international academic partners.
- Advanced the lab's technological capabilities by designing immersive virtual reality (VR) environments and upgrading existing testing infrastructure.
- Engineered custom software tools to streamline in-house sensory data collection for commercial industry projects.
- Served as Principal Investigator for "The Food Metaverse" project, evaluating consumer emotional responses within virtual environments.
- Served as Principal Investigator for the "Rapid Lexicon Development" initiative, creating novel methodologies to evaluate innovative food products.

Research Master Degree Project

Aug 2018 – Dec 2018

Université de Technologie de Troyes (UTT), France

- Developed biosensing platforms for the sensitive detection of the wine spoilage yeast *Brettanomyces bruxelensis* using LSPR, SERS, and QCM transduction techniques.
- Engineered LSPR- and QCM-based biosensors for the rapid detection of gliadin traces in complex matrices.

Industrial Winemaking & Production Operations

2015 – 2019

Assistant Winemaker / Ca' di Rajo, Sutto Wine, San Simone, Barone Ricasoli (Italy)

- Managed industrial-scale vinification workflows, fermentation controls, and real-time quality monitoring during peak harvest operations.
- Developed practical expertise in food safety, process optimization, supplier standards, and operational risk management within commercial production environments.

Teaching, Mentorship & Student Supervision

- **International Student Supervision:** Supervised undergraduate research project cohorts from the Singapore Institute of Technology (across two consecutive academic years) and hosted exchange students from Jiangnan University (China).
- **Degree Thesis Co-Supervision:** Co-supervised one Master's student and one Bachelor's student at the Free University of Bozen-Bolzano, guiding experimental design, chemometric data analysis, and thesis preparation.
- **Ph.D. & Technical Mentorship:** Provided technical mentorship and experimental protocol guidance to Ph.D. candidates at Massey University's Feast Lab (co-authoring high-impact publications in *Food Quality and Preference*).
- **Academic Teaching Assistance:** Delivered laboratory practical demonstrations and assisted course professors during lectures in oenology and sensory evaluation at the Free University of Bozen-Bolzano.

Selected Peer-Reviewed Publications (Top 10)

Bibliometric Summary: 15+ peer-reviewed articles | 238 citations | h-index: 9 | i10-index: 8
(Google Scholar)

1. Mehta, A., Giezenaar, C., Godfrey, A. J. R., Orr, R. E., **Poggesi, S.**, Foster, M., & Hort, J. (2026). Effects of personality traits and context congruency on participant engagement in traditional central location tests and congruent versus incongruent digital immersive environments during affective product testing. *Food Quality and Preference*, 105900.
2. Orr, R., Giezenaar, C., Godfrey, A. J. R., **Poggesi, S.**, & Hort, J. (2026). Context matters: How congruency of digital immersive environment and meal context affect consumer evaluations of plant-based products at two different levels of liking. *Food Quality and Preference*, 137, 105776.
3. Wagner, J., Mehta, A., **Poggesi, S.**, & Hort, J. (2026). Analytic-holistic tendencies differentially impact consumer response dependent on measurement method and context: A case study with chocolate. *Food Quality and Preference*, 105860.
4. Darnal, A., Ceci, A. T., **Poggesi, S.**, Mimmo, T., Boselli, E., & Longo, E. (2026). Chemical, colour, and sensory evolution of Schiava wines: Impact of grape freezing and co-inoculum of yeast and malolactic Bacteria. *Food Chemistry*, 150337.
5. Stickel, L., **Poggesi, S.**, Grunert, K. G., Lähteenmäki, L., & Hort, J. (2025). Do you remember? Consumer reactions to health-related information on snacks in repeated exposure. *Food Quality and Preference*, 126, 105431.
6. Wagner, J., **Poggesi, S.**, Maggs, R., & Hort, J. (2025). The effect of emotional music on Just-About-Right and speeded-responses to chocolate. *Food Quality and Preference*, 105746.
7. Darnal, A., **Poggesi, S.**, Merkytė, V., Longo, E., & Boselli, E. (2024). South-Tyrolean pinot blanc identity: Exploration of chemical and sensory profile changes ascribed to vineyard locations and winemaking variables. *Food Chemistry: X*, 24, 101824.
8. Tchouakeu Betnga, P. F., **Poggesi, S.**, Darnal, A., Longo, E., Rudari, E., & Boselli, E. (2024). Terroir dynamics: Impact of vineyard and canopy treatment with chitosan on anthocyanins, phenolics, and volatile and sensory profiles of pinot noir wines from South Tyrol. *Molecules*, 29(9), 1916.

9. Ceci, A. T., Darnal, A., **Poggesi, S.**, Betnga, P. F. T., Longo, E., Nicolodi, R., Davis, R., Walsh, M., O'Connor, K. E., Altieri, E. A., et al. (2024). Enhancing the stability of a red organic wine through hydroxytyrosol supplementation at bottling: A time-dependent analysis. *Applied Food Research*, 4(2), 100513.
10. Darnal, A., **Poggesi, S.**, Longo, E., Arbore, A., & Boselli, E. (2023). Decoding the identity of Pinot Gris and Pinot Noir wines: A comprehensive chemometric fusion of sensory (from dual panel) and chemical analysis. *Foods*, 13(1), 18.

Selected Conference Proceedings

1. **Poggesi, S.**, Wagner, J., & Hort, J. (2025). The scent of change: How congruent ambient scents in virtual environments affect ice cream tasting. In *16th Pangborn Sensory Science Symposium*, Philadelphia, PA, USA.
2. **Poggesi, S.**, Linklater, R., & Hort, J. (2025). Where will the Foodverse take us? A cross-cultural consumer study in Aotearoa-New Zealand. In *16th Pangborn Sensory Science Symposium*, Philadelphia, PA, USA.
3. Darnal, A., Ceci, A. T., **Poggesi, S.**, Mimmo, T., Boselli, E., & Longo, E. (2025). Effects of winemaking variables on the chemical and sensory quality of Schiava wines up to one year storage in bottle. In *Macrowine 2025: Book of Abstracts*, IVES, pp. 140.
4. **Poggesi, S.**, Darnal, A., Ceci, A. T., Longo, E., Vanzo, L., Mimmo, T., & Boselli, E. (2023). Integrated multivariate statistics, chemical and sensory analysis to create a decision-making tool for marketing Chardonnay and Sauvignon Blanc wines. In *Sensory is Coming Together: 17th NZOZ Sensory Symposium 2023*, NZIFST, pp. 38.
5. Darnal, A., **Poggesi, S.**, Longo, E., & Boselli, E. (2022). Matrix fingerprint analysis of international Sauvignon Blanc and Chardonnay wines using chemometric methods with sensory and analytical profiles in data fusion approach. In *EUROSENSE 2022: 10th European Conference on Sensory and Consumer Research*.

Grants, Funding & Proposal Writing

- **MURF Research Grant (2025):** *Principal Investigator (\$24,800 NZD awarded)*. "Developing a rapid lexicon development methodology for use with innovative food products." Pioneered a high-ecological-validity Home-Use Testing (HUT) method combining AI-assisted thematic analysis, Natural Language Processing (NLP), implicit Response Time Tasks (RTT), and consumer cognitive segmentation for functional beverages with industry engagement (Fonterra, FoodHQ).
- **REaDI Research Seed Fund (2024–2025):** *Principal Investigator (\$5,000 NZD awarded)*. "The Food Metaverse: exploring consumer insights." Executed cross-cultural VR consumer studies (Indigenous Māori and NZ-European cohorts) utilizing Meta Quest 3, Whisper-X transcription, and NVivo qualitative coding.
- **Competitive Grant Proposal Preparation:** Authored a Marsden Fund proposal as Principal Investigator on immersive virtual dining environments, co-investigated a secondary Marsden Fund submission, and contributed to European regional grant applications.

Certifications & Advanced Training

- **Certified Sensory Project Manager:** Italian Society of Sensory Science (SISS) — Advanced professional training in sensory project design, panel management, and consumer insights.
- **Design of Experiments (DoE):** University of Genoa — Specialized coursework in statistical experimental design, factorial modeling, and process optimization.
- **Advanced Mass Spectrometry Training:** Specialized training in high-resolution mass spectrometry, compound identification, and spectral data processing.
- **IELTS Academic Certification (C1 Level):** Overall Band Score 7.0 (Certified 2023).

Technical, Programming & Leadership Skills

- **Sensory & Consumer Methods:** VR tasting room design, implicit Response Time Tasks (RTT), AI/NLP qualitative analysis, sensory lexicon development, Home-Use Testing (HUT), affective/descriptive panel training.
- **Analytical Instrumentation & Chemometrics:** GC×GC-ToF-MS, GC-MS/MS, HPLC-DAD/FLD/MS, multivariate statistical analysis, chemometric modeling, and multi-block data fusion.
- **Programming & Data Science:** R & RStudio, Python, LaTeX, HTML5, CSS3, JavaScript, React, TypeScript.

- **Languages:** Italian (Native), English (Full Professional Proficiency / C1 Certified, IELTS 7.0 – 2023).
- **Leadership & Soft Skills:** Cross-cultural Team Leadership, Commercial R&D Strategy, Grant Writing & Management, Academic Mentoring, Stakeholder Alignment.

Personal Interests

- **Culinary Arts & Fermentation:** Cooking from scratch, artisanal food preservation, and oenology.
- **Outdoors & Well-being:** Trail running, cross-cultural cooking exchanges, and digital technology exploration.